Heidel – Chapter II (part): Sumerian Deluge, Atrahasis, Berossus

▼ Contents

CHAPTER II **2**
- A Sumerian Deluge Version from Nippur^[248] 2
  - Column iii 2
  - Column iv 3
  - Column v 3
  - Column vi 4
  - The Atraḫasis Epic^[261] 5
- Fragment No. I 6
  - Column i 6
  - Column vii 6
  - Column viii 7
- Fragment No. II 7
  - Column i 7
  - Column viii 8
- Fragment No. III 8
- Fragment No. IV 9
  - Column i 9
  - Column ii 9
  - Column iii 10
  - Column iv 12
- The Deluge Account of Berossus 12
- Footnotes (Heidel) 14

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CHAPTER II

RELATED MATERIAL

A Sumerian Deluge Version from Nippur^[248]

Of the various episodes in the Gilgamesh Epic, the one which enjoyed perhaps the most popular favor among the Babylonians and Assyrians, and which certainly is the most important from the viewpoint of the Old Testament scholar, is the story of the great flood and of Utnapishtim's enviable attainment of blessed immortality. This episode originally formed an independent account and has come down to us in a number of different recensions. The oldest of them undoubtedly is the Sumerian version inscribed on a tablet excavated at Nippur. While the tablet itself dates only to about the time of Hammurabi, the story it relates is unquestionably older.

This tablet contains six columns of writing, three on the obverse and three on the reverse. The upper part, representing about two-thirds of the original, has unfortunately been broken off, so that large gaps occur in the text. The preserved portions of the first two columns contain a brief account of the creation and of the founding of five prediluvian cities of Babylonia. The remainder of the composition deals with the story of the deluge, to which the first two episodes are probably introductory. In the preserved portion of the third column the gods have already decided to send a deluge. But not all are ready to carry into execution what has been decreed in the assembly. Nintu, the goddess of birth and here probably identical with the "holy Innanna," laments over the impending destruction of mankind, while Enki, the god of wisdom and the friend of man, is trying to devise ways and means of saving at least one of the human race, his favorite Ziusudra. The text follows.

Column iii

At that time Nintu^[249] [cried out] like a [woman in travail];

Holy Innanna lamented for her people.

Enki^[250] [took] counsel in his own heart.

Anu Enlil,^[251] Enki, and Ninḫursag^[252] [....].

The gods of heaven and earth [call]ed upon the name of Anu Enlil.

At that time Ziusudra^[253] was king, the administrator of the temple provisions of [...].

He made a very great .[...].

He prostrates himself in humility, [....] in reverence.

Daily (and) perseveringly he stands in attendance [at the shrine].

A dream, such as had not been (before), comes forth [....].

He conjures by the name of heaven and earth [....].

The dream mentioned at the end of these lines is evidently related to the warning which Ziusudra receives in the next column, where the purpose of the gods is revealed to him in direct speech.

Column iv

For [....] the gods a wal[l(?) ....].

Ziusudra, standing at its(?) side, heard [a voice]:

"Stand at the wall at my left and [listen].

I will speak a word to thee at the wall; [follow my] word,

[And give] ear (to) mine instruction.^[254]

By our hand a rainflood .[...] will be [sent];

To destroy the seed of mankind, [to ....],

Is the decision, the word, of the assembly [of the gods].

The commands of Anu En[lil ....].

Their rule (and) dominion [....]."

The missing portion of this column, about three-fourths of the text, undoubtedly dealt with the construction of Ziusudra's boat, for the opening lines of the next column already treat of the deluge itself.

Column v

All the mighty windstorms blew together;

At the same time the rainflood swept over the ....^[255]

When for seven days (and) seven nights

The rainflood had swept over the land

(And) the windstorms had driven the giant boat about on the mighty waters,

The sun-god came forth, shedding light over heaven and earth.

Ziusudra opened an opening of the giant boat

(And) let the light of the hero, the sun-god, enter the interior(?) of the giant boat.

Ziusudra, the king,

Prostrates himself before the sun-god;

The king kills an ox (and) offers an abundant sacrifice of sheep.

The remainder of the column, now broken away, probably contained an account of the arrival of the other gods. The final column of the tablet opens with a passage of rather uncertain meaning. Where the text again becomes intelligible Ziusudra prostrates himself before Enlil, who had been chiefly responsible for bringing on the deluge, and, as in the Gilgamesh Epic, Enlil is appeased and bestows divinity and immortality upon the hero of the flood. Ziusudra is then taken to a distant land, the land of Dilmun, on the shores of the Persian Gulf, where henceforth he enjoys the immortal life of the gods.

Column vi

The first five lines of this column are quite obscure. Then the text continues:

Ziusudra, the king,

Prostrates himself before Anu Enlil.

Life like (that of) a god he gives to him,

An eternal soul like (that of) a god he creates for him.

At that time Ziusudra, the king,

(Called) the name of the ... “Preserver of the Seed of Mankind.”

In a ... land, the land of Dilmun,^[256] the place where the sun rises, they caused him to dwell.

What the remainder of the column, about three-fourths of the text, may have contained cannot be determined with certainty. However, we can offer a reasonable conjecture. For the left edge of the tablet contains a line which, though badly damaged, may perhaps indicate that the present deluge version, like so many Babylonian creation stories, was used as part of the introduction to an incantation in order to increase the efficacy of the spell, by reciting some of the mighty deeds of the gods. Should this prove to be correct, it would, of course, mean that the missing portion of this column was inscribed with some magic formula.^[257]

This is the only Sumerian deluge version known at present. Thirty years ago, the late Stephen Langdon of Oxford published a Sumerian myth which he claimed treated of paradise, the flood, and the fall of man. It has since been shown, however, that his interpretation of the text was erroneous and that the story recorded on that tablet has no bearing whatever on the account of the deluge.^[258]

A Semitic Deluge Fragment from Nippur^[259]

In addition to the Sumerian tablet which we have just considered, the mounds of Nippur have yielded also a fragment of a deluge version composed in Old Babylonian. With the exception of the ends of three overlapping lines preserved on the right edge of the tablet, the text of the obverse is completely destroyed; and of the reverse only a few badly mutilated lines have been preserved. Nevertheless, enough of it remains to justify its publication in these pages. The beginning of the reverse is unfortunately broken off. The remainder, together with a few minor restorations, reads as follows.

"[....] I will loosen.

[....] will seize all the people together.

[....] before the flood comes forth.

[....] as many as there are, I will cause overthrow, destruction, annihilation(?).

[....] build a great ship.

[....] total ... shall be its structure.

The same [ship] shall be a giant boat, and its name shall be 'Preserver of Life.'^[260]

[....] cover (it) with a strong cover.

[Into the ship] which thou shalt make,

[Thou shalt bring] beasts of the field (and) fowl of the heavens."

(Remainder broken away)

The Atraḫasis Epic^[261]

Of this great epic, which, according to the colophon on fragment No. II, consisted of at least three large tablets with a total of 1,245 lines, only four deplorably small pieces are known to us. Fragments I and II come from Babylonia and date back to the time of King Ammizaduga (First Babylonian Dynasty), while the other two pieces, belonging to the Assyrian recension of the epic, were found among the ruins of King Ashurbanipal's (668 - ca. 633 b.c.) library in Nineveh.

The fragments at our disposal deal with the story of the deluge, which, according to this version, was preceded by severe plagues which Enlil, the chief of the gods, sent in a vain effort to make people discontinue their noisy gatherings and was followed by the creation of fourteen human beings for the speedy repopulation of the earth. The epic may perhaps owe its origin to the thought expressed by Ea on Tablet XI:177-85 of the Gilgamesh Epic, viz., that Enlil, instead of sending a deluge, should have afflicted mankind with plagues and the like to correct their evil ways; some later mythographer, or group of mythographers, may have taken up Ea's idea and developed it. As we can see from fragment No. IV, the epic was used as a birth incantation to facilitate delivery.

Fragment No. I

Column i

1. [. . . . . .]
2. The land became great,^[262] the peop[le mu]ltiplied;
3. The land became sated(?) like cattle.
4. The god^[263] became disturbed [by] their gatherings.
5. [The go]d heard their noise
6. (And) said to the great gods:
7. "Great has become the noise of mankind;
8. With their tumult they make sleep impossible.^[264]
9. [Let] the fig tree [be c]ut off for the people;
10. [In] their [belli]es let vegetables be wanting.
11. Ab[ove] let Adad^[265] make scarce his [rain],
12. [Below]^[266] let the springs not flow.
13. [Let the floods not rise] from the source.
14. Let the wind blow
15. . . . . .
16. Let the clouds hold back(?)
17. [That rain from heaven] pour not forth.
18. [Let] the field [dimi]nish its products,
19. [Let it turn] the breast of Nisaba."^[267]

From here up to line 387 almost everything is destroyed. Column ii, lines 70-72, can probably be rendered as follows: "In the morning let him cause a heavy rain to [pour down]; let it continue during the night [....].^[268] Let him cause it to rain .[...]."

Column vii

(Beginning broken away)

37. Enki [opened] his mouth
38. [And] said to E[nlil]:
39. “Why hast thou commanded [....]?
90. I will stretch out my hand to the pe[ople(?) ....].
91. The flood which thou dost order [....].”

(Remainder too badly damaged for translation)

Column viii

(Beginning destroyed)

38. Atramḫasis^[269] opened his mouth
39. And said to his lord.

(Colophon:)

40. 37 (lines on this column).
41. Tablet II (of the series): “When God Man.”
42. Its total:^[270] 439 (lines).
43. By the hand of Ellit-Aya, the assistant scribe.
44. The month of Shabâṭu, the twenty-eighth day.
45. The year when Ammizaduga, the king,
46. Rebuilt
47. Dûr-Ammizaduga,
48. At the mouth of the Euphrates.^[271]

Fragment No. II

Column i

(Beginning wanting)

1. [Atramḫasis] opened his mouth
2. And [said] to his lord:
3. “[Of the dream], make known unto me its meaning!
4. [....] make known that I may provide(?) for its ....”
5. [Ea] opened his mouth
6. And said to his servant:
7. “. . . . . .
8. The message which I am about to give thee,
9. Guard thou (it).
10. Wall, listen to me!

11. Reed hut, guard all my words!^[272]
12. Destroy (thy) house, build a ship.
13. Disregard (thy) goods,
14. And save (thy) life!
15. The ship which thou shalt build."

From here to the colophon on column viii virtually everything is destroyed. On column ii the word kupru, "pitch," and the first four letters of the name Atramḫasis are still preserved.

Column viii

(Beginning lost)

1. [....] 390 (lines on the tablet) [....].
2. Total: 1,245 (lines) [....]
3. Of three tablets.
4. By the hand of Ellit-Aya, the assistant scribe.
5. The month of Iyyar, [the ... day].
6. The year when Ammiza[duga, the king],
7. [His] image [....].^[273]

Fragment No. III

(Beginning broken away)

1. ". . . . . .
2. [....] like the vault(?) [....].
3. [....] strong above and b[elow].
4. [....] close [....].
5. [....] at the appointed time, of which I will inform th[ee],
6. Enter [the ship] and shut the door of the ship.
7. [Bring in]to it thy grain, thy goods and chattels;
8. Th[y wife], thy family, thy relations, and the craftsmen.
9. [Game] of the field (and) beasts of the field, as many as eat herbs,
10. [I will s]end unto thee, and they shall guard thy door."^[274]
11. [Atr]aḫasis opened his mouth and said,
12. [Spea]king to Ea, [his] lord:
13. "[Ne]ver have I built a ship [....].
14. Draw a de[sign of it on the gr]ound,
15. That I may look upon the [desi]gn and [build] the ship.
16. [....] on the ground d[raw(?) ....].
17. [Then I will carry out(?)] what thou has commanded [me to do]."

(Remainder broken away)

Fragment No. IV

Column i

(Beginning broken away)

25. [When the second ye]ar [arrived ....].
26. [When the thi]rd year [arrived],
27. The people changed in their [....].
28. When the fourth year ar[rived, ...] their ... were in straits.
29. Their wide [...] became narrow.
30. The people [wan]dered about in the streets downcast.^[275]
31. When the fifth year arrived, the daughter looks for the entrance of the mother;^[276]
32. (But) the mother does not open h[er] door to the daughter.
33. The daughter lo[oks] upon the balances of the mother;
34. [The mother] looks upon the balances of the daughter.^[277]
35. When the sixth year arrived, they prepared [the daughter] for a meal,
36. For food they prepared the child. Full were the [....].
37. One house [devoured] the other.
38. Like unto the ghost(s) of the dead^[278] their faces [were covered].^[279]
39. The people [lived] with bated [breath].
40. They took a message [....].^[280]

(Remainder almost completely destroyed)

Column ii

(Beginning wanting)

29. Above [Adad made scarce his rain];
30. Bel[ow] (the fountains) were stopped, [so that the flood did not rise at the source].
31. The fie[ld dimi]nished [its products],
32. [It turned the breast of] Nisaba. [During the nights the fields became white];
33. [The wide-open plain b]rought forth sa[lt;^[281] her bosom^[282] revolted],
34. [So that no plant came for]th, [no] grai[n sprouted].
35. [Disease was let loose upon the people].
36. [The womb was closed, so that it could not bring forth a child].
37. [. . . . . .].
38. [When the second year arrived, ...] the supply.
39. [When the third year] arrived,

40. [The people] changed [in their ....].
41. [When the fourth year arrived, ...] their [...] were in straits.
42. [Their wide ...] became narrow.
43. [The people wandered about] in the streets [downcast].
44. [When the fifth year arrived], the daughter looks for [the entrance of] the mother;
45. (But) [the mother does not op]en her door [to the daughter].
46. [The daughter] looks upon [the balances of the mother];
47. The mother looks upon [the balances of the daughter].
48. [When the sixth year arrived, they prepared] the daughter for a meal,
49. [For food] they prepared [the child].
50. [Full were the ....]. One [house] devoured the other.
51. [Like unto the ghosts of the dead their faces] were covered.
52. [The people] lived [with bated] breath.
53. [The wise] man Atraḫasis
54. Turns his thoughts^[283] [to Ea, his lord];
55. [He speaks] with his god.
56. [His lord, E]a, speaks with him.^[284]
57. [....] the gate of his god.
58. By the river he places his bed.^[285]
59. [....] the rain(?) ....

Column iii

(Beginning broken off)

1. . . . . .
2. [Because of] their noise he^[286] is distur[bed];
3. [Because of] their tumult he cannot catch any [sleep].^[287]
4. [Enl]il held a meeting.
5. [He sa]id to the gods, his sons:
6. “Great is the noise of mankind.
7. [Because of their] noise I am disturbed;
8. [Because of th]eir [tu]mult I cannot catch any sleep.^[288]
9. [....] let there be malaria.
10. [Instantaneous]ly the pestilence shall put an end to their noise!
11. [Like] a storm let it blow upon them,
12. [Sick]ness, headache, malaria, disease!”
13. [....] there was malaria.
14. [Instan]taneously the pestilence put an end to their noise.
15. [Like] a storm it blew upon them,
16. [Sic]kness, headache, malaria, disease.

17. [The wi]se man Atarḫasis
18. Turns his thoughts [to] Ea, his [lord].
19. [He s]peaks with his god;
20. [His lord], Ea, speaks with him.
21. Atarḫasis opened his mouth, saying
22. To Ea, his lord:
23. “Lord, mankind groans.
24. Your [anger(?)] consumes the land.
25. O Lord Ea, mankind groans.
26. [The anger(?)] of the gods consumes the land.
27. [....] ye have created us.
28. [Let] sickness, headache, malaria, (and) disease [be cut] off.”
29. [Ea opened his mouth and] said to Atarḫasis, as he addressed him:
30. “[...]. in the land.
31. [....] pray to your goddess.”

32-36. (Destroyed)^[289]

37. [Enlil] held a meeting (and) said to the gods, his sons:
38. “[...]. do not place them.
39. [The people] have not become fewer, (but) are more numerous than before.
40. [Because of] their noise I am disturbed;
41. [Because of] their tumult I cannot catch any sleep.
42. Let the fig tree [be cut] off for the people.
43. [In] their bellies let vegetables be wanting.
44. Above let Adad make scarce his rain;
45. Below [let (the fountains) be] stopped, so that the flood cannot rise at the source.
46. [Let] the field diminish its products;
47. [Let] it turn the breast of Nisaba. During the nights let the fields become white;
48. Let the wide-open plain bring forth salt.
49. Let her bosom^[290] revolt, that no plant may come forth, no grain may sprout.
50. Let disease be let loose upon the people.
51. Let [the womb] be closed, that it bring forth no child.”
52. They cu[t off] the fig tree for the people.
53. In their bellies vegetables became wanting.
54. Above Adad made scarce his rain;
55. Below (the fountains) were stopped, so that the flood could not rise at the source.
56. The field diminished its products;
57. It turned the breast of Nisaba. During the nights the fields became white;
58. The wide-open plain brought forth salt; her bosom revolted,
59. So that no plant came forth, no grain sprouted;

30. Disease was let loose upon the people.
31. The womb was closed, so that it could not bring forth a child.

Column iv

(Beginning destroyed)

8. [....] they kissed her feet,
9. [Saying: "The creatress of mankind] we call thee.
10. [The lady] of all the gods be thy name!"
11. [They went] to the house of destiny,
12. [Nin]igiku, (that is,) Ea, (and) wise Mama.
13. [Fourteen w]ombs were gathered together,
14. To tread upon the clay before her.
15. [....] said Ea, as he repeatedly recited the incantation.
16. Ea caused her to recite [the incanta]tion as he sat before her.
17. [Mama recited] the incantation. After she had recited^[291] her incantation,
18. [.... she] threw upon her clay.
19. [Fourteen pie]ces she pinched off; seven pieces she laid on the right.
20. Seven pieces she laid on the left; between them she placed a brick.
21. [...]. opened its navel.
22. [.... she] then called the wise women(?),
23. [Seven a]nd seven wombs; seven created men,
24. [Seven] created women.
25. The womb(s), the creatresses of destiny,
26. They complete them, (yea), them(?);^[292]
27. Them(?) they complete before her.
28. The forms of the people Mami forms.
29. In the house of the bearing one the woman in travail shall let the brick lie for seven days.
30. .... from the temple of Maḫ, the wise Mami.
31. They that are angry(?) let them rejoice in the house of the woman in travail.
32. As the bearing one gives birth,
33. May the mother of the child give birth by herself.^[293]

(Remainder broken away)

The Deluge Account of Berossus

The latest known Babylonian deluge version is that of Berossus, a priest of Marduk at Babylon. It is taken from the history of Babylonia which he compiled from native documents and published in Greek about 275 b.c. His writings have perished, but extracts from his history have survived to

our day. Of his account of the flood we have two excerpts, both of which are, in turn, based upon an excerpt made by Alexander Polyhistor (last century b.c.). The first and more important of the two reads as follows:^[294]

After the death of Ardatēs,^[295] his son Xisuthros reigned for 64,800 years; under him a great deluge took place; the story has been recorded as follows: Kronos^[296] appeared to him in (his) sleep and revealed (to him) that on the fifteenth of the month Daisios^[297] mankind would be destroyed by a deluge. He therefore commanded (him) to set down in writing the beginning, middle, and end of all things, to bury (these writings) in Sippar,^[298] the city of the sun(-god); to build a boat, and to go aboard it with his relatives and close friends; to store up in it food and drink, to put into it also living creatures, winged and four-footed, and, when all was made ready, to set sail. If asked whither he was sailing, he should say: "To the gods, in order to pray that it may be well with mankind!" He obeyed and built a boat, five stadia^[299] in length and two stadia in width; all these orders he carried out and embarked with (his) wife and children and his close friends.

After the deluge had occurred, Xisuthros let go some birds as soon as it ceased; but as they found no food nor a place to alight, they returned to the ship. After certain days Xisuthros again let the birds go; these again returned to the ship, but with their feet stained with mud. But, when they were let go for the third time, they did not again return to the ship. Xisuthros concluded that land had appeared; and, unstopping a part of the seams of the ship and perceiving that the ship had grounded upon a certain mountain, he disembarked with (his) wife, (his) daughter, and the pilot; and after he had prostrated himself to the ground, had built an altar, and had sacrificed to the gods, he disappeared with those who had disembarked from the ship. Those who had remained on the ship disembarked when Xisuthros and his companions did not return, and sought him, calling (him) by name; but Xisuthros himself never appeared to them; however, a voice came from the air, commanding them to be god-fearing, as was proper; for because of his piety he had gone to dwell with the gods, and his wife and (his) daughter and the pilot had received a share in the same honor. (The voice) told them also that they should go back to Babylon and, as had been decreed unto them by fate, that they should recover the writings at Sippar and pass (them) on to men; also that the land where they were belonged to Armenia.

When they had heard these things, they sacrificed to the gods and went on foot^[300] to Babylon. But of this ship that grounded in Armenia some part still remains in the mountains of the Gordyaeans in Armenia, and some get pitch from the ship by scraping (it) off, and use it for amulets. These, then, went to Babylon, dug up the writings at Sippar, founded many cities, erected temples, and rebuilt Babylon.

The second excerpt, which Abydenus (probably second century a.d.) made on the basis of Polyhistor's epitome,^[301] runs thus:

After him reigned others, (among them) also Sisithros,^[302] to whom Kronos foretold that on the fifteenth of Daisios there would occur copious rains; (wherefore) he commanded (him) to hide all available writings in Sippar, the city of the sun(-god). As soon as Sisithros had carried out these commands, he sailed for Armenia, and immediately the rainstorms sent by the god came upon him.^[303] The third day, after the rain had subsided, he sent forth (some) of the birds to determine whether they could see land emerging somewhere from the water; but (the birds,) greeted by an unbounded sea (and) at a loss where they should alight, returned to Sisithros, and others after them (did likewise). But when upon the third trial he succeeded—for they returned with their feet full of mud—the gods removed him from the ken of man. But the vessel in Armenia furnished the inhabitants with wooden amulets to ward off evil.

Footnotes (Heidel)

[248] Inscription published by A. Poebel, Historical and Grammatical Texts (Philadelphia, 1914), Pl. I; translated by the same author in his volume Historical Texts (Philadelphia, 1914), pp. 18 ff.; and translated again by L. W. King, Legends of Babylon and Egypt in Relation to Hebrew Tradition (London, 1918), pp. 63 ff.
[249] Commonly known as Ninḫursag.
[250] Another name for Ea.
[251] In this text Enlil is consistently referred to as "Anu Enlil." This title indicates that Enlil has received the supreme power and functions of Anu, the highest god of the Sumerian pantheon, and that he thus exercises not only his own authority but also that of Anu (cf. Poebel, Historical Texts, pp. 36-37).
[252] A goddess of birth and rulership.
[253] On this reading see Thorkild Jacobsen, The Sumerian King List (Chicago, 1939), pp. 76, n. 34, and 217 (K 11624).
[254] Cf. S. N. Kramer in the Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research, No. 79 (October, 1940), p. 26.
[255] Cf. Jacobsen, op. cit., p. 59.
[256] On this reading of the name see Kramer in the Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research, No. 96 (December, 1944), pp. 18-19.
[257] Cf. King, op. cit., pp. 50-51.
[258] See Kramer in the Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research ("Supplementary Studies," No. 1 [1945]).
[259] Text published and translated by H. V. Hilprecht, The Babylonian Expedition of the University of Pennsylvania, Series D, Vol. V, Fasc. 1 (Philadelphia, 1910); and translated again by A. T. Clay, A Hebrew Deluge Story in Cuneiform (New Haven, 1922), pp. 81-82; Erich Ebeling in Hugo Gressmann, Altorientalische Texte zum Alten Testament (Berlin and Leipzig, 1926), p. 199; and others.
[260] Cf. Poebel, Historical Texts, p. 61, n. 3.

[261] Text of fragment No. I published by Clay, op. cit., Pls. I-II, with photographs on Pls. V-VI; of No. II by A. Boissier in Revue d'Assyriologie, XXVIII (1931), 92-95, with photographs facing p. 91; of No. III by Friedrich Delitzsch, Assyrische Lesestücke (Leipzig, 1885), p. 101, and Sir H. C. Rawlinson, The Cuneiform Inscriptions of Western Asia, Vol. IV (London, 1891), Additions, p. 9; and of No. IV by King in Cuneiform Texts from Babylonian Tablets, etc. in the British Museum, Vol. XV (London, 1902), Pl. 49, and K. D. Macmillan in Beiträge zur Assyriologie, V (1906), 688. Translations by P. Jensen, Assyrisch-babylonische Mythen und Epen (Berlin, 1900), pp. 255 ff. and 275-91; R. W. Rogers, Cuneiform Parallels to the Old Testament (New York and Cincinnati, 1926), pp. 103-7 and 114-21; Clay, op. cit., pp. 58-69; D. D. Luckenbill in the American Journal of Semitic Languages and Literatures, XXXIX (1922/23), 155-59; Ebeling in Gressmann, op. cit., pp. 200-206; Ebeling, Tod und Leben nach den Vorstellungen der Babylonier (Berlin and Leipzig, 1931), pp. 176-77; Boissier in Revue d'Assyriologie, XXVIII, 95-96; and others.

[262] Lit.: wide.

[263] The god par excellence, meaning Enlil in this case (cf. fragment No. IV, col. iii).

[264] Reading ⌈ú⌉-za-am-ma shi-it-ta (see Sidney Smith in Revue d'Assyriologie, XXII [1955], 67-68).

[265] The god of storm and rain.

[266] The copy has ḫi-pí ish-[shu], "a new break," which means that at this point the scribe found a new break on the tablet from which he was copying. On the basis of fragment No. IV, as well as from the context, the missing word can easily be supplied.

[267] Nisaba was a goddess of grain. The meaning of this line is: "The field shall not permit grain to grow up."

[268] Cf. W. F. Albright in the American Journal of Semitic Languages and Literatures, XL (1923/24), 135.

[269] Later forms of this name are Atraḫasis and Atarḫasis.

[270] The total of the tablet, not counting the lines of the colophon.

[271] I.e., the eleventh year of Ammizaduga's reign.

[272] Reading zi-ik-ri(!)-ia, as suggested by Dr. F. W. Geers. The text has zi-ik-zi-ia.

[273] Since almost all of the date formula is destroyed, it is impossible to say whether it refers to the fifth, the ninth, the twelfth, the fifteenth, or the seventeenth year of Ammizaduga's reign, as the term alam, "image," occurs in the date formulas of all these years (see Reallexikon der Assyriologie, II, 189-91). In view of the fact that this text was written by the same scribe who copied fragment No. I, the twelfth year seems to be the most likely.

[274] This undoubtedly means that the animals shall remain indoors, in the ship.

[275] Reading qa-da-nísh.

[276] Evidently forsaken by her husband because of the famine, the daughter returns to the home of her mother.

[277] All disinterestedness has ceased; everyone expects full weight and measure from the other, even the mother from the daughter, and vice versa.

[278] Reading she-dim me-te. Reading and translation uncertain.

[279] Cf. col. ii, 51, and the Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet VIII, col. ii, 17.
[280] After six years of punishment the people became quiet and were granted rest and prosperity, but after a certain period they again disturbed the peace of Enlil (cf. col. iii) and were afflicted anew.
[281] On this translation of idranu see Smith in Revue d'Assyriologie, XXII, 63-64. Under the influence of the drought, the ground became covered with salt.
[282] The bosom of Nisaba, whence the fields of grain derived their nourishment.
[283] Lit.: His ear is opened.
[284] After the clay of the tablet was nearly dry, the scribe wrote la-shú ("there is or was nothing") on the blank space between it-ti-shú ("with him") and i-ta-mu ("he speaks") to indicate, for some reason, that the original from which he had copied had an uninscribed space between these two expressions. In the parallel passage, col. iii, 20, this remark is not found.
[285] Apparently for the purpose of securing rain by means of enchantment, for which he undoubtedly had the blessing of Ea, his lord. Atraḫasis evidently was successful in his efforts; but, since the people became as hilarious and tumultuous as before, they were punished again.
[286] Enlil.
[287] Lit.: [Sleep] does not catch him. Reading i-ṣa-ba-su [shi-tu] (so Smith in Revue d'Assyriologie, XXII, 67).
[288] Lit.: Sleep does not catch me.
[289] As indicated by what follows, Atraḫasis again effected a cessation of the plague; but, since men again incurred the displeasure of Enlil, they were punished for the fourth time.
[290] The bosom of Nisaba.
[291] Var.: completed.
[292] The people(?) (cf. line 28).
[293] I.e., may the delivery be so easy that no assistance is required.
[294] Text in Eusebi chronicorum libri duo, ed. Alfred Schoene, Vol. I (Berlin, 1875), cols. 20-24. Translated by A. M. Harmon in Clay, op. cit., pp. 82-83; Rogers, op. cit., pp. 109-12; Ebeling in Gressmann, op. cit., pp. 200-201; and others.
[295] On column 10 of the work from which we have taken the present story, Eusebius calls this king Ōtiartēs (Ὠτιάρτης), which is a corruption of Ōpartēs (Ὠπάρτης), corresponding to the Babylonian Ubara-Tutu. Both Ardatēs and Ōpartēs may go back to a form Ōpardatēs, or the like (cf. Jacobsen, op. cit., p. 75, n. 32).
[296] Corresponding to the Babylonian Ea.
[297] Corresponding roughly to the month of May.
[298] A town in northern Babylonia. The text has Sispara throughout.
[299] The Armenian version has "fifteen stadia." This is probably a scribal error, which may be due to the preceding date "on the fifteenth of the month Daisios" (so Paul Haupt in Beiträge zur Assyriologie, X, Heft 2 [1927], 26).
[300] Thus the Armenian version. The Greek has "by a roundabout way" (πέριξ).
[301] See P. Schnabel, Berossos und die babylonisch-hellenistische Literatur (Leipzig and Berlin,

1923), pp. 164 ff. Text in Eusebi chronicorum libri duo, ed. Schoene, Vol. I, cols. 32-34. Translated by H. Usener, Die Sintfluthsagen (Bonn, 1899), p. 15, and B. Bonkamp, Die Bibel im Lichte der Keilschriftforschung (Recklinghausen, 1939), pp. 131-32.

[302] Identical with Xisuthros. A few lines preceding our text, Abydenus calls him Sisuthros.

[303] Lit.: and immediately the things from the god came upon him. The god referred to evidently is the chief god of the pantheon, and not Kronos (i.e., not Ea).